

BOG WATCH

A question about Article III of the NSS Constitution

Did the members vote on the 2024 change of wording?

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Every image is a page published by the NSS, with a link to the file it came from. Files retrieved 23 Sep 2026; facts as of 2 Oct 2026.

Not an official NSS document. Yellow boxes on the page images were added to mark the words that changed.

Article VIII: how the Constitution can be changed

Current Board Manual (July 2026), Article VIII

VIII. Amendments to this Constitution may be proposed by either the Board of Governors or by petition of five percent of the regular or higher membership of the Society. Proposed amendments will be mailed to all regular or higher members of the Society. Amendments will be adopted by a two-thirds favorable vote of all ballots returned within ninety days of the mailing.

<https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/09/Board-of-Governors-Manual-2026-07-06.pdf#page=6>

June 2023 Board Manual, Article VIII

VIII. Amendments to this Constitution may be proposed by either the Board of Governors or by petition of five percent of the regular or higher membership of the Society. Proposed amendments will be mailed to all regular or higher members of the Society. Amendments will be adopted by a two-thirds favorable vote of all ballots returned within ninety days of the mailing.

[Wayback: caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=10](https://web.archive.org/web/20230620100000/https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=10)

Three requirements

- 1 Proposed** by the Board of Governors, or by a petition of five percent of regular or higher members.
- 2 Mailed** “to all regular or higher members of the Society.”
- 3 Adopted** “by a two-thirds favorable vote of all ballots returned within ninety days of the mailing.”

The article has no exception for small, clerical or single-word changes, and gives the Board no power to adopt an amendment itself.

Article III: “appoint officers for the Society”

Constitution, standalone PDF, 2008

III. The government of this Society shall be by a Board of Governors which shall have full power to conduct and supervise all business of the Society, draft and adopt the Bylaws of the Society, make changes therein, appoint officers for the Society, and perform all other functions incident to the proper conduct of the Society.

[Wayback: www.caves.org/nss-business/bog/Constitution.pdf](https://www.caves.org/nss-business/bog/Constitution.pdf)

Internet Archive copy of 17 May 2008

Constitution, standalone PDF, uploaded 20 Jun 2022

III. The government of this Society shall be by a Board of Governors which shall have full power to conduct and supervise all business of the Society, draft and adopt the Bylaws of the Society, make changes therein, appoint officers for the Society, and perform all other functions incident to the proper conduct of the Society.

https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/NSS_Constitution.pdf

Still live on caves.org with this wording (checked 23 Sep 2026)

Board Manual, “As of 30 May 2022”

III. The government of this Society shall be by a Board of Governors which shall have full power to conduct and supervise all business of the Society, draft and adopt the Bylaws of the Society, make changes therein, appoint officers for the Society, and perform all other functions incident to the proper conduct of the Society.

https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=10

Live on caves.org

Board Manual, “As of 20 June 2023”

III. The government of this Society shall be by a Board of Governors which shall have full power to conduct and supervise all business of the Society, draft and adopt the Bylaws of the Society, make changes therein, appoint officers for the Society, and perform all other functions incident to the proper conduct of the Society.

[Wayback: caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=10](https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=10)

Internet Archive copy of 19 Oct 2023

Article III: “appoint Executive Director for the Society”

Board Manual, “As of July 1st, 2024”

III. The government of this Society shall be by a Board of Governors which shall have full power to conduct and supervise all business of the Society, draft and adopt the Bylaws of the Society, make changes therein, appoint Executive Director for the Society, and perform all other functions incident to the proper conduct of the Society.

https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/07/Board-of-Governors-Manual-2024-7-1_0.0.pdf#page=6

Live on caves.org

Board Manual, “As of the March 14, 2026 meeting”

III. The government of this Society shall be by a Board of Governors which shall have full power to conduct and supervise all business of the Society, draft and adopt the Bylaws of the Society, make changes therein, appoint Executive Director for the Society, and perform all other functions incident to the proper conduct of the Society.

https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=6

Live on caves.org (this address is overwritten by each new edition)

Board Manual, “As of the September 30, 2024 meeting”

III. The government of this Society shall be by a Board of Governors which shall have full power to conduct and supervise all business of the Society, draft and adopt the Bylaws of the Society, make changes therein, appoint Executive Director for the Society, and perform all other functions incident to the proper conduct of the Society.

[Wayback: caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=6](https://web.archive.org/web/20250916120000/https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=6)

Internet Archive copy of 16 Sep 2025

Board Manual, “As of the July 06, 2026 meeting”

III. The government of this Society shall be by a Board of Governors which shall have full power to conduct and supervise all business of the Society, draft and adopt the Bylaws of the Society, make changes therein, appoint Executive Director for the Society, and perform all other functions incident to the proper conduct of the Society.

<https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/09/Board-of-Governors-Manual-2026-07-06.pdf#page=6>

Live on caves.org; the most recent edition

Compared word by word, this is the only change to the nine articles between the June 2023 and July 2024 Manuals.

How Article IX was amended in 2013–14

Minutes of 14 July 2014, item 4 (as posted on caves.org):

4) Report of Motion to Amend Constitution of the National Speleological Society, INC, Article IX

Section 8 of the Constitution states in part: “Amendments will be adopted by a two-thirds favorable vote of all ballots returned...”

Item 13 of Appendix X of the Acts states “When required, the President may put a Bylaw or act referendum, along with a pro and a con position statement, on the ballot to be voted on.” Due to both time constraints with a change in the D.C. Corporation Act and as a cost-saving measure to the membership, President Shrewsbury placed the following motion on the Director Election Ballot:

Shrewsbury moved: The National Speleological Society Constitution is amended as follows: IX. The organization of this Society shall **<be under Title 5, Chapter 5, of the Code of the District of Columbia, and shall>** become effective as of January 1, 1941.

After the required 90 days had passed and the election cycle complete, the results were:

Membership in favor: 1,839 (93.2%)
Membership against: 135 (6.8%)

PASSED

caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/boardminutes/1407BOG.pdf#page=2

Nov 2013

The Board passes the motion to amend Article IX (item 26)

Mar 2014

“There will be a NSS Constitutional Amendment on the ballot” (President’s report)

Spring 2014

On the director election ballot, kept open 90 days

Result

1,839 in favour (93.2%), 135 against

14 Jul 2014

Result reported to the Board and minuted (item 4)

Manual

Recorded under the Constitution: “07/14/14:4 - Article IX”

The amendment record printed under the Constitution

June 2023 Manual

IX. The organization of this Society shall become effective as of January 1, 1941.

Amended:
06/72
07/14/14:4 - Article IX

[Wayback: caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=10](https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=10)

Before the wording of Article III changed

July 2026 Manual (most recent)

IX. The organization of this Society shall become effective as of January 1, 1941.

Amended:
June 1972
Article IX: 07/14/14:4

<https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/09/Board-of-Governors-Manual-2026-07-06.pdf#page=6>

After

The same two entries, before and after: June 1972, and Article IX on 14 July 2014. The format was tidied in 2024; nothing was added.

There is no entry for Article III in any of the four editions published since July 2024.

What the public record shows for the Article III change

Found

The Board adopted the restructuring on 10 March 2024, 16–0. The motion amends “bylaws and acts (including appendices)”. It does not name the Constitution.

Found

A floor amendment allowed “clerical changes” replacing “president” with “Executive Director”, in three named Acts (18-640, 18-747, 18-986).

Not found

A Constitution section in the 144-page restructuring proposal.

Not found

The word “Constitution” in any public Board minutes or agenda from June 2023 to July 2026, apart from the text of one fund Act.

Not found

A ballot notice, a vote count, or a Manual entry for Article III, as there is for Article IX in 2014.

Not checked

NSS News and election notices. They are member-only, and a ballot would be announced there.

The question

NSS members who voted in the 2024 or 2025 director elections, or who keep their NSS News:

Do you remember a ballot question on amending Article III of the NSS Constitution?

Until 2023, Article III said the Board of Governors may “appoint officers for the Society.” Since the Board Manual of 1 July 2024 it says “appoint Executive Director for the Society.” (Images 1 and 2.)

Article VIII says amendments are mailed to members and adopted by a two-thirds vote of the ballots returned within ninety days. (Image 3.) That is how Article IX was amended in 2014: 1,839 to 135, reported in the Board minutes. (Image 4.)

I (Aaron Bird) have not found a ballot, a result or a minute for the Article III change in the public record. I have not been able to check NSS News (I’m being strict about this). If there was a ballot, could someone point me to the notice and the result?

Links to every source are on the next slide.

Every file, with its link and fingerprint

Constitution PDF, 2008 (Wayback 17 May 2008)	https://web.archive.org/web/20080517111905/http://www.caves.org/nss-business/bog/Constitution.pdf	77a62e1e3605
Constitution PDF, uploaded 20 Jun 2022 (live)	https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/NSS_Constitution.pdf	671e73cffbb7
Board Manual “As of 30 May 2022” (live)	https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=10	ed485d97d593
Board Manual “As of 20 June 2023” (Wayback 19 Oct 2023)	https://web.archive.org/web/20231019112853/https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=10	9912990e3cb1
Board Manual “As of July 1st, 2024” (live)	https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/07/Board-of-Governors-Manual-2024-7-1_0.0.pdf#page=6	ae179bf9a9c
Board Manual “As of the September 30, 2024 meeting” (Wayback 16 Sep 2025)	https://web.archive.org/web/20250916214603/https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=6	5d655996ef11
Board Manual “As of the March 14, 2026 meeting” (live)	https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/businessdocuments/Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf#page=6	36eca742ff55
Board Manual “As of the July 06, 2026 meeting” (live)	https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/09/Board-of-Governors-Manual-2026-07-06.pdf#page=6	4f744b603738
Minutes, 9 Nov 2013, item 26 (live)	https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/boardminutes/1311BOG.pdf	
Minutes, 14 Jul 2014, item 4 (live)	https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/boardminutes/1407BOG.pdf#page=2	4150d98547ca
Minutes, 10 Mar 2024, item 5.5 (live)	https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/p/boardminutes/2403BOG.pdf	
NSS Restructuring Proposal, 2024-2-7 (live)	https://caves.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/02/NSS-Restructuring-Proposal_2024-2-7.pdf	3288dc3c25f1